ONE-OFF SHIURIM

How Does Witchcraft Work?

Derech Hashem 3:2:8-9

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 2, paragraphs 8-9 (end of the chapter) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 25 November 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Two good ways, recalled

The Rabbi recalled the two ways a person can move nature. The first is connecting directly to the Kadosh Barukh Hu, bypassing the regular chain; this requires great righteousness. The second is invoking the angels responsible for particular tasks, which then must fulfil their role faster and more powerfully unless God intervenes; this requires knowledge more than righteousness. And as Hazal and the Ramhal warn, even one who knows how should not use it unless he is fitting. Now we come to the wrong ways: black magic.

Paragraph 8: good and evil in parallel

As learned in Part 1, there must be good and bad in the world, and evil must be able to exist at all its levels. Our service is to prevent its manifestation and rule until it is completely removed. "That essentially is what our purpose in this world is."

God's essence has no deficiency at all; only in creation can deficiencies exist. So God arranged levels of good and, in parallel, levels of bad, by withdrawing Himself and allowing evil to exist. Wherever there is good, there is a parallel bad.

A participant recalled that the balance was not quite equal. The Rabbi agreed: the root and source of good is God Himself, while evil is only a creation, which exists for the period of human service, that is, this world. So the parallel is real, but good has the greater source.

Paragraph 9: unnatural darkness

Why does this matter here? We have learned that there are unnatural ways to reach God: directly, through the angels, even through sleep. So, by the rule of parallels, there must also be unnatural ways to bring down darkness.

The natural way to bring darkness into the world is sin, and sin has its limit. But a person can also draw down impurity and concealment of God, which means randomness and chaos, unnaturally. This is what is called tumah, kishuf (witchcraft) and necromancy, all of which the Torah forbids.

A participant asked whether this is simply the parallel of the angels' names. The Rabbi said it is similar, with a difference: there are no truly "bad angels", only angels whose purpose is to do something bad. And here the Ramhal also speaks of the dead. There is nothing evil in a dead body as such, but it has a vacancy where the soul was, which is why it is impure, and the tumah rests there. Through certain names, a person attaches himself to the exact opposite of cleaving to God and draws down levels of impurity, and can use this to change nature in a negative way.

Examples from the Torah

Who did this in Tanakh? Bilam. And, as the Ramhal says, the Egyptian hartumim with their secret arts. In Mikes Pharaoh's hartumim cannot interpret his dream, so he turns to Yosef. In Vaera, Moshe turns the water to blood and they do the same. They too could act beyond nature, according to the energy they drew, through the names of negative angels and through demons.

Why is a witch called a mekhashef? The Rabbi cited Hazal's explanation that witches are *makhishin pamalya shel maalah*: they run contrary to the heavenly retinue. Connected to the wrong sources, they can act against what is willed above.

God can still stop it

But only to the extent that they trigger it, and even then God can prevent it. Just as He can stop a holy name from working, He can stop a negative one.

The Rabbi linked this to free will, discussed long ago. If God decrees on Rosh Hashanah that a person will live the coming year, that means he will not die of natural causes; another person still has the free will to kill him. But God can say, "I need him, I'm going to prevent it." So too with witchcraft.

He brought the Gemara about Rabbi Hanina: a woman tried to take dust from under his feet to bewitch him, and he answered that "there is none besides Him", *ein od milevado*. "If you truly, truly believe that, not just we say it, we say it every day, if you truly believe it and you live your life like that, nothing to worry about." Even the best witchcraft will not bring you down. And the Gemara adds that someone of great merit pushes away those who wish to harm him.

The road ahead

That ends chapter 2. Chapter 3 begins Ruah HaKodesh and prophecy; chapter 4 explains how prophecy works; chapter 5 shows how Moshe Rabbenu differed. Because of Hanukkah there would be no class the following week, and the series would resume on the Monday after.

Summary

- Everything good has a parallel bad, but good has the greater source, since evil is only a creation for this world.
- Just as there are unnatural ways to reach holiness, there are unnatural ways to draw down impurity.

- Witchcraft and necromancy work through negative names, demons and the impurity of the dead; Bilam and the hartumim are the Torah's examples.
- Witches act against the heavenly order, but only as far as God allows.
- One who truly lives by *ein od milevado* has nothing to fear from witchcraft.

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